

Hunger-waker

Bishops' Sagas

Norse Sagas

translated by Frederick York, 1905

Plato Scroll · **plato-scroll.com**



Scan to read online, free and offline
plato-scroll.com/s/norse-hunger-waker/

HUNGER-WAKER

1

Here beginneth Hunger-waker.

2

1. THIS LITTLE BOOK I call HUNGER-WAKER, inasmuch as it appears to many uninformed men, wise though they be, that have gone through it, that they would wish to know much more thoroughly the rise and the life of those notable men of whom little is told forth in this scroll, though I have cast together into my book well-nigh all that I have fast in my memory.

3

2. I have put together this little book in order that there might not altogether fall out of my memory what I heard that man of knowledge, Gizor Hallsson, say on the matter thereof, and what certain other notable men have set forth in narrative.

4

This also in the second place hath led me to write this, that it might draw young men on to make themselves acquainted with our speech [letters] and to read what is written in the northern tongue, Law or Histories or Biographies.

5

3. I have rather set this matter down in a scroll, than such other kind of knowledge as hath been already set in scrolls, because methinks that it is for my children or other young men in the highest degree right to know, first and foremost, how and in what way Christendom hath grown to strength here, and how the bishops' sees were set in Iceland; and, secondly, to know what notable men the bishops that have been here have been, of whom I am purposed to speak.

6

4. Moreover this reason also enforceth me to write how the see hath grown and waxed strong in Seal-holt, and of the conversation of those

men that have had it in their keeping — to wit, that I have by the grace of God gotten from them all my furtherance in this world.

7

5. And I am aware that to wise men this little book will seem most like unto the stuff- out of which a horn-spoon is wrought, for that is most ungainly while it is yet a-making, but very fair when it is carved.

8

6. But they that seek amusement from this little book may profitably use it for their own entertainment and that of such others as are willing cautiously to hearken thereto, rather than jeopard themselves in other pastimes to while away dull hours. For many a man hath proved this, that if he will seek him short-lived pleasure there must needs follow thereafter long penance.

9

7. Methinks it is good that a man shall pick out of this goodly matter that is here written, whatsoever he liketh best and whatsoever yieldeth him pleasure, and let him lay up in his mind that which falleth in with his mind, but drop that which doth not fall in with his fashion of thought.

10

8. And methinks that for such it is better that they should mend that which they think to be told poorly here, and which they know somewhat more thoroughly, rather than that they should cry it down or turn it into mockery, and yet be neither willing nor able to mend it for themselves.

11

9. And for this cause also I have likened this to a horn-spoon, because methinks there is much good stuff- therein, but I know that there is much need that it be beautified or fair wrought, and I shall as long as I am able busy myself to the mending thereof.

12

10. I also am the more bound to do this, because it is my fault and my lack of care if, in the matter that is here written, there be anything

which shall turn out to be wrong, and not the fault of those men of whom I have said that I have drawn my knowledge thereof.

13

11. And inasmuch as there is an old saw, that *it is the house that bolds the man*, I will speak first of how the house was settled at Seal-holt, and afterwards of them that have been the keepers of the see.

14

1. 1. CETIL-BEORN THE OLD dwelt at Moss-fell, and had many children. Tait was the name of a son of Cetil-beorn. He was so fortunate that he first set up the homestead that is called Seal-holt, which is now the noblest house in all Iceland. This was his second piece of good fortune, that he had for a son Gizor the White, who came with Christendom to Iceland, and dwelt in Seal-holt after his father Tait. Gizor the White had three wives. First he had to wife Hall-dora, daughter of Hrod-wolf o' Goatland; their daughter was Wil-borg, whom Sholto Scegge's son had to wife. Then Gizor had to wife a woman from the islands [Western Islands], whose name was Thor-dis, and their son was Cetil, who had to wife Thor-katla, Skapte's daughter. Then Gizor had to wife Thor-dis the daughter of Thor-ord the gode o' Hiall in Aulfus, and they had many children.

15

2. Their son was IS-LAF. Gizor took him abroad, and put him as a disciple with an abness in a town that is called Her-forth.

16

When Is-laf came back to Iceland he was a priest and well learned. He married and took to wife Dolla, the daughter of Thor-wald o' Ridge. They got three sons. Gizor was the name of one, who afterwards was bishop; the second was named Tait, who dwelt in Hawk-dale; the third was named Thor-wald, who dwelt at Hrawn-garth, a great chief. Gizor the White had the first church set up in Seal-holt, and was buried there at that church. But Is-laf dwelt at Seal-holt after his father.

17

3. Is-laf was a fair man to look on, and well beloved of all men, and all his life upright and honest, generous and benevolent, but never a wealthy man. But when Is-laf was fifty years old (and Iceland had not been christened any longer than that), then he was bidden to go abroad, and chosen as bishop by the whole commonweal in Iceland. Then he went abroad and southward to Saxland, and went to see the emperor, Henry Conradsson, and gave him a white bear that had come from Greenland, and this beast was the greatest treasure, and the emperor gave Is-laf his writ with his seal to go over all his dominions. Then he went to see pope Leo. And the pope sent his writ to Adalbert, archbishop of Bremen, that he should give Is-laf the consecration of a bishop on Whit-Sunday, and the pope said that he was in hope that by God's grace this bishopric should be a long-enduring office if the first bishop were consecrated to Iceland on the day in which God blessed the whole world with the gift of the Holy Ghost. And Is-laf was consecrated bishop on that day, according to the pope's command, by Adalbertus, archbishop in Bremen, fourteen nights before Columba's mass-day [26th May, 1056]. And the archbishop gave him all the insignia that he needed to have with the office of bishop, according as the pope and the emperor had sent him word.

18

4. After this bishop Is-laf came the same summer to Iceland, and set up his bishop's see at Seal-holt. He had much trouble in many ways in his bishopric because of the disobedience of men. And it may be somewhat of a token of what need he hath been in by reason of the lack of faith, and the disobedience, and evil conversation of those under him, that the Law-speaker had to wife mother and daughter. And in those days some men lay at sea on wicking cruises and in war ships, and many betook themselves to many other abominations which would now be thought shocking if men were to commit them.

19

5. In the days of bishop Is-laf there came hither bishops from other lands and gave easier commands than bishop Is-laf, wherefore they

found favour with evil men, until archbishop Adalbert sent his writ out to Iceland and forbade men to receive any service at their hands, and saying that some of them were excommunicated, and that all had come without his leave.

20

6. In the days of bishop Is-laf there came to Iceland a bishop whose name was Col, and he died here. He was buried at Seal-holt. Now this church was the first here in this country that was honoured by the burial of a man of rank, the church which by right may be called the ghostly mother of all other consecrated houses in Iceland.

21

7. Bishop Is-laf kept all through a straitened household as regards money. The revenue was little, but the calls upon it were many, and thereby the household was strained.

22

7. b. Many men sent him their sons (see Libellus 9. 1).

23

8. But when Is-laf had been bishop four-and-twenty winters he was taken ill at the All-moot, at mass, so quickly and suddenly that he was forced to put off his mass-vestments at once, and then priest Guth-thorm, Fin-wolf's son of Bath-dale, by the order of the bishop put on the mass-vestments and went on with the mass where the bishop left off, and ended the mass. Then the bishop was brought home to Seal-holt, and a room prepared for him in the church. And there men were seeking him for counsel, both as to the choice of a bishop and as to other things which they thought it was needful to speak about. And he gave them this counsel, that they should ask Guth-thorm the priest to go abroad [to be hallowed bishop], saying that he was the best fitted of all them that were then in the country; nevertheless he said that they would be long getting a bishop in Iceland, unless they promised to behave in more seemly wise to him who should succeed him than they had done to himself..

24

9. In the latter part of the life of bishop Is-laf there appeared many things about him which very clearly showed forth his goodness before the face of those men who knew how to look at them, insomuch that many mad folk were brought to his hand that went away whole after they had seen him. He blessed drink that darnel had got into, and it was good to drink afterwards; and many another such thing happened about him, although I do not now tell over one by one all things that he did, and which seemed to the wisest men to show that he must have the greatest power *in working miracles*.

25

10. Is-laf was consecrated bishop when he was fifty years old. Harold Sigurdsson was then king over Norway. Bishop Is-laf died on the Lord's-day in the church at Seal-holt at midday, [three] nights before the Sel-men's-mass [5th July]. He had then been bishop four-and-twenty winters, and he was buried by the tomb of bishop Col. There was then passed from the birth of Christ 1073 years [July 5, 1080].

26

11. It is told that bishops came out hither to Iceland in the days of bishop Is-laf, but Frederick was the only one that came out before of whom stories were made. But these are those who have come here of whom men have taken most account: —

27

Bishop John the Irishman; and some men hold for true that he afterwards went to Wendland and that there he turned many to God, and at last he was taken and flogged, and both his hands and feet cut off, and last of all his head, and in such torment he departed to God.

28

The third bishop that came to Iceland was Beom-hard Wilradsson, who was called the Book-wise, and such men say that he was from England, and that he had followed St. Olaf, and had afterwards by his counsel journeyed to Iceland.

29

The fourth bishop was Rud-olf, whom some say was called Wolf, and he was by kin of Ruda [Rouen] in England [Normandy]. He was nineteen winters in Iceland, and dwelt at By in Borg-frith.

30

Fifth came to Iceland bishop Henry, and he was two winters in Iceland.

31

The sixth was bishop Bearn-hard the Saxlander, and he was with king Magnus the Good, the son of Olaf. Afterwards he journeyed to Iceland, and was here twenty winters. He had two households in Water- dale — Gill-water and Stan-stead. He hallowed many things which bear many marks thereof, church and bells, causeways and brooks, fords and rivers, rocks and small hills, and all those things are held to have shown forth true proofs of his goodness. Beam-hard was in Iceland while king Harold Sigurdsson was in Norway, inasmuch as they were not at one. Afterwards he went out of the country, and took service with king Olaf the Peaceful, the son of Harold, and afterwards he went to Rome at the prayer of the king, and made peace for the dead. And when he came back the king made him bishop of Selia, and afterwards he went to Beorg-win [Bergen], and there he died, and it is said by all that he was a man of the greatest note.

32

12. In the days of bishop Is-laf there were many and great tidings. There was in Norway the fall of king St. Olaf; then came about also the death of king Magnus the Good, the son of king Olaf, and he died in Denmark, but his body was brought north into Thrond-ham to Nith's-mouth [Nidaros], Both these died ere Is-laf was bishop; but after he was bishop king Harold Sigurdsson fell in England, and a little later Harold Godwinesson. There died king Magnus, son of Harold Sigurdsson, and Swain Wolfsson, king of the Danes [in Iceland there died], and Thor-kell Eywolfsson, Gelle Baul-werksson, Thor-stan Cogsson, Snorre the gode, and men of great account.

33

2. 1. GIZOR, the son of bishop Is-laf, was born in Seal-holt, but he was taught in Saxland [Saxony], and was hallowed priest straightway in his youth. But when he came out to Iceland he married and took to wife Stan-wen Thor-grim's daughter, whom Thore Brorde's son had to wife before, and they kept house first at Temple in Weapon-frith.

34

2. Gizor was a big man of stature and portly, bright-eyed and somewhat open-eyed, of noble presence, and the most kindly of men; strong of body, and a wise man. Gizor was finished in all those qualities which a man ought to possess. He was a great traveller the early part of his life as long as Is-laf was alive, and was always held worthy wherever he went, and he served men of rank while he was abroad. King Harold Sigurdsson was then king of Norway, and he spoke these words of Gizor, saying that he could see that he was very well suited to bear any rank he might get. He and his wife went to Rome before they came back to Iceland.

35

3. Gizor was not in the country when his father died, but he came out here the second summer before the All-moot to Rang-water-mouth, and was on board some nights, for he would not ride to the Moot as long as none had been chosen bishop at the Moot. The chiefs asked Guth-thorm the priest to go abroad [to be hallowed bishop], according as they thought bishop Is-laf had specially directed, and at last he consented, if there were thought to be no better choice. But when Gizor heard that priest Guth-thorm was appointed to go abroad, then he went to the Moot. But when Gizor came to the Moot, then priest Guth-thorm walked forth to the parvis before the church and declared to the whole commonalty that there was no question of his going out [for consecration] now that they could choose Gizor. Then all the commonalty turned to Gizor and prayed him to go abroad, but he excused himself in many ways; nevertheless it came about at the last that he consented to undertake this difficult charge, and all the chiefs

promised to pay obedience to all God's ordinances [the canon law] that he should order if he were hallowed bishop.

36

4. Then he went abroad that same summer. But when he came to Saxland archbishop Liemarus had been deprived of all his power. Therefore he went to see pope Gregory [VII], and told him all that happened before and during his journey, and also the difficulties by which he was in many ways beset. But the pope sent Gizor to Hard-wig, archbishop of Magdeburg in Saxland, and bade him to give him the consecration of a bishop, and he received him with great honour and worshipfully, and hallowed him bishop four nights before the latter Mary-mass or Lady-day [Sept. 4, 1082]. He was then forty years of age, and the archbishop gave him all that he lacked for his present needs.

37

5. After this bishop Gizor came out to Iceland, and the whole commonalty received him gladly. He received such rank and honour immediately at the outset of his bishopdom that every man would sit or stand as he bade, young or old, rich or poor, women or men, and it is true to say that he was both king and bishop over the land as long as he lived.

38

6. He had not all the land at Seal-holt for his farm at first for some while, because his mother Dalla wished to keep up a household on her share of it as long as she lived. But when she was dead and the bishop came into the whole land, then he bestowed it all upon the church that is in Seal-holt, which he himself had had built thirty [fathoms] long and hallowed to Peter the Apostle. And with much other wealth did Gizor endow this church both in lands and money, and he said moreover that there should always be a bishop's see while Iceland was inhabited and Christendom lasted. Bishop Gizor gave to the church in Seal-holt a white purple-hackle [mass-cope], which has long been the best there, and many other treasures.

39

7. ‘ These men were of the same time as bishop Gizor: Sæ-mund the priest o’ Orde, who was the best both of wise men and clerks; secondly, Marcus Scegge’s son, the law-speaker, who was the greatest sage and poet. They took counsel together and brought this counsel before the chiefs, that it should be made law that men should give tithes of their stock every season, and of all the legal increase of their stock, as was the custom in other lands where Christian men dwell. And from their consultation and wise persuasive speeches the end of the matter was that men took upon themselves the payment of tithe, and the tithe was to be dealt into four shares — one for the bishop, another for the church, a third share the clerks should have, and a fourth share the poor. And there hath been no such foundation in Seal-holt for wealth and profit as this tithe-tax, which was laid on by reason of the popularity and power of bishop Gizor. [See Libellus 10. 3.]

40

8. Stan-wen Thor-grim’s daughter kept the household in Seal-holt indoors while bishop Gizor ruled the see, and Dalla while bishop Is-laf lived.

41

9. But when bishop Gizor had been established in his see for twenty winters or near that time, the North-land-men made petition to him that they might have a bishop of their own, and set up a second bishop’s see in the North-land-men’s Quarter, and that he should endow the same with the fourth of the whole revenues of his diocese, and that there should be two bishop sees in the land; and they said that they hoped that this once done there would be every hope they would seldom or never be bishopless in the land if there were two bishop sees there. And this petition bishop Gizor granted for God’s sake to the North-land-men, and afterwards there was chosen to bishop, by God and good men, priest John Og-mund’s son. And he went abroad with a writ of bishop Gizor’s, and afterwards went to see pope Paschalis, and he was hallowed bishop by Auzur, archbishop of Lund in Sconey [April 29], two nights before Philip-and-James-mass.

42

Then John went to Iceland and set up his bishop's see at Holar in Sholto-dale in Shaw-frith.

43

10. [See Libellus 10. 6.]

44

11. But when bishop Gizor was half-eighty [75] years old, so great heaviness came upon him that he did not rise from his bed and could not go to the Moot. Then he sent word to his friends and all the chiefs at the All-moot that men should pray priest Thor-lac the son of Run-olf to go abroad [to be hallowed bishop]. But he excused himself both by reason of his youth and for many other causes. Nevertheless the end of the matter was that he consented to undertake the burden if it were the bishop's will. Then bishop Gizor had him equipped for his journey, and gave him his writ to archbishop Auzur.

45

1 a. But his sickness increased upon bishop Gizor, and became hard, strong and painful, and there came great sores upon his flesh down to the bone, and there was great pain from his disease. But when the sickness began to overcome him, and men thought they could hear his bones rattle when he was moved, then goodwife Stan-wen went to his bed and asked him how low should a man's strength become when there should be vows made for him? But the bishop answered, 'For this only should ye make vows to God, that my pain should go on ever increasing, if a vow be made at all, as long as I am able to bear it; for it is not permitted that a man should have himself prayed out of God's battle; and now my life must be well-nigh at its end, and ever up to now things have gone sun-ward [happily] with me.' He was also asked then where he would have himself buried, but he answered with compunction and great lowliness, 'By no means bury me near my father, for I am not worthy to rest near him.' Then he set all things in order according as he would have them to be before he died.

46

13. His sons were all dead before him, save Bead-were only. Groa, his daughter, lived after him; she was given in marriage to Cetil Thorstan's son.

47

14. Gizor was hallowed bishop when he was forty years old, when Olaf the Peaceful was king in Norway, the son of Harold Sigurdsson. Bishop Gizor died the third day of the week, twelve nights before Columba-mass [May 28]. He had then been bishop thirty-six winters. He was buried by his father. There were then passed from the birth of Christ eleven hundred and eleven winters [1118].

48

15. The death of bishop Gizor touched many men so deeply that it never went out of their mind as long as they lived. And all men were agreed on this, that they believed they would never get his peer, and it was the verdict of all wise men that he hath been by God's grace and by his own good parts the noblest man *that hath ever been* in Iceland, whether of clerks or laymen.

49

16. [See Libellus 10. 12.]

50

17. [See Mantissa 1. 1, p. 267.]

51

18. And it was the belief of the wisest men that it looked as if Iceland was drooping after the death of bishop Gizor, as the realm of the city of Rome did after the fall of pope Gregory [*the Great*], and the loss of bishop Gizor betokened [or pointed to the quarter of] all kind of distress in Iceland from bad seasons, both in wrecking of ships and loss of life and damage to stock that accompanied it, and after that in civil war and breaking of the laws, and upon the top of that such a mortality over all the land that there hath never been such since the land was dwelt in.

52

Two winters after the loss of bishop Gizor, Haf-lide Mar's son was wounded at the All-moot, and the case was not judged that summer.

53

19. Bead-were alone of the sons of bishop Gizor was alive when he died, but there died before him his other sons, Tait, As-geir, Thord, and John. Groa lived also long after, and became a nun, and died at Seal-holt in the days of bishop Clong.

54

20. In the bishopdom of bishop Gizor there were many great tidings: — The loss of the holy king Cnut at Fion [Funlfn] and of Benedict his brother, of the two Williams kings of England, the death of king Olaf the Peaceful, and Hacon Magnusson in Norway, the fall of Magnus Bare-le's west in Ireland in Ulaztir [Ulster], the translation of Saint Nicholas bishop of Bari, the death of king Olaf Magnusson: in Norway, the passion of Saint Magnus the earl, the death of the law-speakers Marcus [and] Ulf-hedin, and of Tait Is-laf's son, and the other sons of bishop Is-laf, the coming up of fire [eruption] in Hecla, and many other great tidings, though they be not written down here.

55

3. 1. THOR-LAC, the son of Run-olf, the son of Thor-lac, the son of Thor-arin, the son of Thor-kel Coll o' Scots, and the son of Hall-frid, daughter of Snorre, the son of Carls-efne, was brought up with his father in his childhood, but he was schooled at Hawk-dale. He was early of good understanding and manners, and in favour with all good men. He was greatly given to books even in his youth, and quick of understanding, and disposed to clerkship. He was gentle and lowly, and no meddler, of wholesome counsel, and whole-hearted towards all men that were with him, meek-mannered and merciful with all that needed it, fond of his kindred, and full of foresight in all matters, both those which concerned himself and others. Thor-lac was two winters of the fourth ten [32] when he was chosen bishop, and therein it maybe noted what a man he was, sincere chose him for the greatest of charges

who was the wisest and noblest and best acquainted with him, that is bishop Gizor.

56

2. Thor-lac was a man of middle height, long of face, and light-brown of hair, nice looking, but not called a fair man by the generality of folk, nor of great presence according to most men's reckoning. And when he came abroad it was thought that there could be no great choice of men in the country, for he seemed to them not the man to be presented to such an office. But he answered himself that it was not that, and he said that the real reason was that he had rather concealed his faults before man than before God; and by this answer men thought they could perceive that he was well suited to such an office. And when he came to see archbishop Auzur he soon saw what manner of man Thor-lac was, and received him honourably and worshipfully, but yet he made some difficulty about his consecration, and said that he could not put head upon head; nevertheless at the message of bishop Gizor he promised him consecration, but he would not consecrate him to the see wherein there was already another bishop, and he bade him choose him another see, that he might be consecrated, but yet he gave him leave that he should be in Seal-holt if bishop Gizor gave him leave if he were alive when bishop Thor-lac came back.

57

3. Thor-lac was hallowed bishop three nights before Philip-and- James-mass [April 28], and he was hallowed to the see of Reek-holt in Borg-frith. He was hallowed in Denmark thirty days before bishop Gizor died at Seal-holt.

58

4. Bishop Thor-lac went to Iceland the same summer that he was hallowed, and men received him gladly as was his due. He kept the same lowliness in his bishopdom as he had had before, and he let all his qualities wax and none wane as long as he lived. He took many men as his disciples or scholars, and they afterwards became good clerks, and in many ways he strengthened Christendom in Iceland.

59

5. When bishop Thor-lac had sat three winters in the see at Seal- holt, there died bishop John Agmund's son at Holar [1121], but afterwards there was chosen in his place Cetil Thor-stan's son, and he went abroad southward to Denmark, and was hallowed bishop there ten nights after Candle-mass [Feb. 12, 1122], and came out to Iceland the same summer afterwards.

60

6. Bishop Thor-lac brought things so far in his days that the Christian Law Section was established, and written according to the provision of the wisest men in the country and by the advice of archbishop Auzur, and they were both stood by to the furtherance thereof, bishop Thor-lac and bishop Cetil. And many another thing was there which they established and put together, or ordained in their days for the reform of the people of this country.

61

7. Bishop Thor-lac offered Hall Tait's son of Hawk-dale to foster one of his sons, and therefore Gizor Hall's son came to Seal-holt, and the bishop was so loving to him as he was to his own sons, and foretold what afterwards came to pass, that there should scarcely be found such a man of note in Iceland as he would be, and this was proved afterwards.

62

8. The same priest served Thor-lac always as long as he lived and was bishop, whose name was Tiorve the son of Bead-were, a man of great goodness, and who had been before with bishop Gizor, and by this and by his other daily noble manners how even-minded he was to good in his life.

63

9. He used to sing every day a third part of the psalms slowly and clearly, and between times he used to teach or write or read over the holy scriptures, or give healing counsel to those that needed it and came to him. He was never idle. He was bountiful to the helpless, but

was called close-fisted by the commonalty, though he never spared money in needful cases for anything that required it.

64

10. But when bishop Thor-lac was three years short of fifty years of age [47], he took an illness after Yule, and lay in the dormitory where he and his clerks were wont to sleep. And when this illness began to increase he bade them read to him the book that is called *Cura Pastoralis*, which Gregory the pope wrote, and wherein is told minutely how he shall order his way withal who shall be a governor of other men. And men thought they could see that he was in better heart respecting his own death after than he had been before the book was read to him. Then he made ready against his death [*only such men having entrance to his sick chamber*] as he himself chose, but the common people did not know at all how his sickness went on till his death.

65

11. Thor-lac was hallowed bishop in the days of pope Gelasius. He was then three winters of the fourth ten [33]. He died [Jan. 31] the eve of St. Bridget's-mass. He had then been bishop fifteen winters, and he was buried beside the former bishops. Ey-stan and Sigurd the Jerusalem Journeyer were then kings in Norway. There was then passed from the birth of Christ eleven hundred and twenty-six winters ["33]-

66

12. This circumstance took place in the north of the land the same day that bishop Thor-lac died, that at that very hour a learned and noble priest, whose name was Arne, the son of Beorn Carleif's son or Carls-efni's son, was going on his way, when he heard a fair song up in the heaven over him, and there was sung this *cantilena* of bishop Lambert:

—

67

Sic animant Claris coelorum reddidit as tris, and it was found when the matter was looked into that no man had been near there. Wherefore many men paid great heed to this circumstance, and did not let it fall from their memory.

68

13. There is much notable and excellent to say of bishop Thor-lac Runolfs son. These tidings came about in his bishopdom, that there died Saint John bishop of Holar, and king Ey-stan and Sigurd the Jerusalem Journeyer. Priest Sæ-mund the historian died in the same spring [May 22, 1133], bishop Thor-lac having died the winter before. There was also the slaying of Thor-stan Hallward's son, and Thore Simon's son. Berg-thor the Law-speaker died then. Then was the lawsuit between Haf-lide Mar's son and Thor-gils Ord's son. Then also the peace between them came about.

69

14. Many chiefs were troublesome to bishop Thor-lac by means - of their disobedience, and some in evil life and breach of law, but he managed everything in the best possible way.

70

4. 1. MAGNUS was the son of Einar, the son of Magnus, the son of Thor-stan, son of Hall o' Side, and of Thor-rid, the daughter of Gils, the son of Hafr, the son of Swerting, the son of Hafr Beorn, the son of Molda-Gnup. Magnus was brought up with Einar, his father, and Ord-ny, his step-mother, the daughter of priest Magnus Thord's son of Reek-holt. They used to say that they loved him most of all their children. Magnus was put to his books and hallowed to all the orders before he became a priest.

71

2. Magnus was a fair man to look on, rather tall of stature, fair eyed, and well limbed, cheerful and pleasant mannered, and of the finest presence whether as regards his carriage or conversation. He was easy and lowly to all, magnanimous and steadfast in mind, resolute, loving to his kinsfolk, of good knowledge, and of fair speech. He proved also well suited to either estate, farming or trading abroad; he was above all a peace-maker wherever he was engaged in men's suits, and to this end he spared nought — neither words nor money.

72

3. But when bishop Thor-lac died in the winter, the summer following Magnus was chosen bishop, and that summer he meant to go abroad [for his consecration], but was driven back to Blond-mouth, and was in Seal-holt through the winter, and went to Norway the next summer after.

73

He went abroad the summer that Magnus Sigurd's son and Harold Gille fought their battle at Fyri-laf, and Harold fled away south to Denmark [1134]. Magnus the bishop-elect went that same harvest-tide to Denmark, and gave gifts to king Harold, and there sprung up great friendship between them. Magnus went to see archbishop Auzur, and he received him worshipfully and hallowed him bishop on Simon's mass-day [Oct. 28, 1174]. The next winter after bishop Magnus was in Sarps-borg, until king Harold got into the country again; then he went to him and the king received him gladly and with the greatest worship and honour, and he was with him till he went back to Iceland, and he received worshipful gifts from the king — a drinking-cup which weighed eight marks, and there was afterwards a chalice made out of it, and many other gifts, for the king was bountiful and generous to his friends.

74

4. Bishop Magnus came to Iceland about the All-moot time, and came into Ey-frith, and rode to the Moot, and reached it while men were at the court, and there was a disagreement about a certain case, but with that there came a man into the court and said that bishop Magnus was just riding into the Moot. And men were so glad to hear this, that they all went home at once. And afterwards the bishop went out to the parvis in front of the church, and told all men these tidings that had come to pass in Norway whilst he was abroad, and all men thought much of his good speaking and fine presence.

75

5. And it was soon proved what a noble man he was in his magnanimity and prudence, both for himself and others, in that he never

spared any outlay as long as he was bishop to bring them to peace that were before at odds with one another, and he would always contribute out of his own to make up the difference between them; hence there arose no feuds between men as long as he was bishop. He kept the same lowly behaviour to the commonalty as before though he was bishop, and was on this account more beloved than most other men, and he had done great many things to deserve it.

76

6. Bishop Magnus had the church at Seal-holt much enlarged, and then hallowed it, and the church day was fixed at the Selia-men's mass [July 8], but before then it had been at Cross-mass in the spring [May 3], when bishop Gizor had hallowed it. Bishop Magnus had the church hung with the tapestry, or brodered hangings, which he had brought out, and they were the greatest treasures. He also brought over the pall or brocade out of which that hackle or cope was made, which is called 'Scarmending.'

77

7. He also strengthened the see much by many endowments, which have long been of the greatest profit both to the see and also to those who have had it in charge. He bought, for the see in Seal-holt, Arness and Sand-tongue and well-nigh all the West-man islands before he died, and purposed to have set up a monastery there, but his life did not last long enough.

78

8. But when bishop Cetil was now well seventy years of age, he went to the All-moot and commended himself to the prayers of all the clerks in the synod of priests. And then bishop Magnus asked him to come home with him to Seal-holt to keep his church day [dedication feast] and a bridal that was to be there. The feast was so very splendid that it was a pattern after in Iceland; there was much mead mixed, and all other stores of the best that might be. But the Friday evening both bishops went to bathe at Bath-ridge after supper. And then it came to pass that bishop Cetil died there, and men thought this great news [July 6, 1145].

There was great grief at this feast among many of the guests till the bishop was buried and service done for him. But by the comforting speeches of bishop Magnus and the noble drink that was provided, men got their sorrow the sooner out of mind than they would otherwise have done.

79

9. And after that Beorn Gil's son was chosen bishop of Holar, and he went abroad with a writ of bishop Magnus to archbishop Ansel, and Beorn was hallowed bishop the next day after Cross-mass in spring [May 4, 1147] and came out hither the same summer, and was bishop at Holar fifteen winters.

80

10. But when fifteen winters were passed from the death of bishop Thor-lac Runolf's son, when bishop Magnus had been bishop fourteen winters, there befell Iceland such a calamity, as the like had never been for loss of men, when bishop Magnus had gone over the West-firths, and was in Hot-river-dale at Michaelmas. But the next day after, Michaelmas-day [Sept. 30, 1148], the house caught fire at supper-time, and the bishop was not aware of it till 'it was manifest that it was not possible' to get out, and it was as if he would not haste away to fly the awe of death which he could then see was upon him, because he had always prayed Almighty God that He would give him such a death as might manifest a cleansing passion [baptism of martyrdom] for him. Bishop Magnus lost his life there in the burning of the house, and with him two-and-seventy men. There died priest Tiorve Beadware's son who had always served him as *chaplain* in his bishopdom. There were seven priests more burnt, and all men of good family.

81

The bodies of the bishop and Tiorve were well-nigh unburnt, and were both carried to Seal-holt, and then there were sent two men of understanding to Fleets-lithe, priest Paul Solwi's son and God-mund Codran's son, to tell these news to Hall Tait's son and Eyjolf Sæmund's son and the other chiefs that were there at a feast with him. They went

forth at once to Seal-holt, but from the West there came with the bodies of the bishop and Tiorve, priest God-mund Brand's son and Snorre Swerting's son and many more men of worship, and reached Seal-holt on Denis-mass [Oct. 9]. But on Jerome's-day [Oct. 10] the bodies were buried beside the graves of the former bishops. And naught more distressful hath ever happened than there did then in Hot-dale, where men were so fatally parted, that well-nigh every one had to part with a beloved friend.

82

11. Magnus was hallowed bishop by archbishop Auzur in the days of pope Anacletus, in the days of king Harold Gille and Magnus Sigurd's son, kings of Norway. He was then a winter more than half forty [36]. But he died in the house burning in Hot-river-dale, the fifth day of the week, one night after Michael-mass [Sept. 30]. There had then passed from the birth of Christ eleven hundred and forty winters and one [1148], and he had then been bishop fourteen winters.

83

12. While Magnus was bishop, the townsfolk betrayed Harold Gille, and then fell king Magnus Sigurd's son and Sigurd the false deacon; then came about the slaughter of Thore Stan-mod's son, and the death of archbishop Auzur, and of Raven son of Ulf-hedin the law-speaker, and of Finn the law-speaker, and of Henry king of England; and many another thing came about in his days which was great tidings.

84

5. 1. AFTER the death of bishop Magnus, the next summer they proceeded to choose a man to bishop, and Hall Tait's son went abroad. *[He went to Rome and back again, and he spoke their speech everywhere, as if he were a native of the place at which he was at. Hall died at Trect [Utrecht?] as they were on their way back, and he was not yet hallowed bishop. And when the news of his death got about in Iceland, and men must needs choose another bishop, it was the choice of all that had a voice, and the advice of Beorn bishop of Holar, to choose to*

bishop a north-countryman, whose name was CLONG, and he was the son of Thor-stan and of Hall-dora Eyjolfs daughter.

85

2. Clong was a fair man to look on, and of middle stature, brisk, and of good presence and accomplished and a good penman, and the best of clerks. He was a good speaker, and true to his friends, and a very good poet. He had been with bishop Cetil, and in many particulars had his good ways of life.

86

3. Clong went out the same summer as he had been chosen bishop with the writ of bishop Beorn to go to archbishop Ansel, and he hallowed Clong bishop twelve nights after Mary-mass in spring [April 6], The very next summer he came out to Iceland. And there was then come from the south from Rome and all the way from Bari Gizor Hall's son, and he came out to Iceland with him, and so men had to welcome together the two greatest jewels of men that were in Iceland. On board the two ships there came out big timber, which bishop Clong had hewn in Norway for the church which he had made in Seal-holt, and which was in every way glorious above every other building that was built in Iceland, both with regard to its timbers and to its workmanship.

87

4. And when the bishop came to the see in Seal-holt, he was straightway so beloved by the commonalty that even those men held him most dear when he had been a short while in the see, that had formerly been rather set against him in their hearts. And it is natural that it should, have been so, for he was magnanimous and a generous giver to his friends, and open-handed and an alms-giver to the poor. Lenient and lowly to all, cheerful-he was and jocular, and an even-tempered man with his friends [a man of authority and decision], so that he was looked to for all decisions, as long as he was in the see, whatever kind of thing there was need of there.

88

5. He began his church-building when he had been one winter in his see. It seemed to others that there was a great outlay in church building every season, both in stores of timber and skilled workmen's wages, and the keep of them that were employed. And men of understanding thought that it would take up all the money revenue of the see, both tithes and other incomes. On the other hand, there was such great outlay needed for the household every season, by reason of the number of people, and hospitality, and other outgoings, or calls, that it seemed as if *that* would need all the revenue which the see possessed. In the third place, he had such largely attended feasts, and great gifts he gave his friends who were both many and of good estate, so that there was needed for this outlay endless money. But Almighty God, that giveth all good as He willeth, let him fall short of naught that he needed, whether for his church building or other calls upon him which the bishop wished to maintain as long as he lived. These were the chief of the workmen at the church in Seal-holt: Arne, who was called the master-workman, and Beorn the skilful the son of Thorwald; Illugi Leif's son also wrought on the wood *as carpenter*. And when the church was quite finished Run-olf bishop's son [bp. Cetil's son] made this verse on it: —

89

Proud is the hall that the ruler raised to Christ:

90

Such a plan springs from a good root.

91

It was of good omen that Beorn built this house of God:

92

Peter [the Patron] hath acquired the noble handiwork of Arne and Beorn.

93

[Corpus Poet. Bor ii. 282.]

94

6. Bishop Clong was so great a lawyer that he was alway sought to or consulted for help in most cases, both because he was a great chief, and by reason of his wisdom and of his power of speaking; he was also very well versed in the Constitution: wherefore those chiefs always had the better in their cases whose party the bishop joined, and no great case was decided without bishop Clong being called upon by both sides. They were also his trustiest friends that were the most worshipful men in Iceland, John Loft's son and Gizor Hall's son. Bishop Clong also exchanged gifts with the greatest chiefs in other lands whom he came near to. And in such wise he became well-beloved both abroad and in his own land.

95

7. And when the church was finished at Seal-holt, and the bishop thought it fit for hallowing, he made a great feast and noble to his friends, and bade thither bishop Brand and abbot Nicholas [of Thwart-water], and many chiefs; and there was a very great number of guests bidden. They both hallowed the church at Seal-holt, Clong and Beorn, the one without and the other within, and both hallowed it to Peter the Apostle as it had been before; but abbot Nicholas held the discourse [?]. This was on the day of the passion of Vitus [June 15]. And after the hours, bishop Clong asked all those who had been at the hallowing of the church, and who thought fit to do so, to take dinner there. And this was done more out of magnificence than prudence, because it is always found to go one way when a man depends or listens to many fools in cases where one wise man may well foresee with prudence. And these gave proof of this forthcoming, for there were no less than seven hundred [840] men took dinner there, and the stores began to run short before the end. But the feast was very splendid as all those thought who were bidden there, and all men of worship were sent on their way with great gifts.

96

8. Bishop Clong had the church that he had built at Seal-holt adorned in the best way he could, until it was fairly fitted in every way. He had a

gold chalice made and set with gem-stones, and gave it to the church. He also had a book of hours written much better than what was there before. It was his whole business at once to teach the young priests, and recite and sing the psalter, and he would give orders withal wherever it was needed. He was more self-disciplined in many ways than the other bishops before him had been, in vigils and fastings and wearing of garments. He would often walk bare-foot of a night in snow and frost.

97

9. When Clong had been bishop ten winters, bishop Beorn of Holar died two nights after Luke's-mass [Oct. 20, 1163], when he had been bishop fifteen winters. And the next summer priest Brand Sæ-mund's son was chosen bishop, and he took out with him the writ of bishop Clong to go to archbishop Ey-stan withal, and he was hallowed bishop on the last Mary-mass [Sept. 8], and he was in Beorg-win [Bergen] through the winter, and John Loft's son also, and afterwards the bishop came out [to Iceland] the next summer, and sat down in his bishop's see at Holar, whereto he was hallowed.

98

10. Bishop Clong kept up till his old age his dignity and popularity, so that all they that were most worthy held him in high worth. But when he began to grow old there came upon him a great disease, and it took him first in the feet, which began to break open because of the cold and penance and discomfort he had had. But when he began to grow weary, because of old age and lack of health, then he sent out his writ to archbishop Ey-stan asking his leave to put off his hand and give over the land and duties of his bishopric, and to take another man to be bishop in his stead, according to the example of bishop Gizor. But word came back from the archbishop that he had leave to choose and send a bishop to be hallowed, but that he should maintain the performing of the hours and preaching so long as he was able, though he were not able to make his visitations.

99

11. Bishop Clong went to the All-moot and there sought of the chiefs that a man should be chosen as bishop, but it was the wish of all that he himself should choose him whom he would, and he chose Thor-lac Thor-hall's son who was then abbot in Thick-by. And it was a great piece of good fortune for bishop Clong to have chosen that man after him who is now a true saint, and all men know that there hath never been any man in Iceland proven so to be, save the holy bishop Thor-lac who was thus chosen bishop. Bishop Clong still kept the management of the bishop's stead [Seal-holt] that season, albeit it was not easy to manage, for at that time there was [but a poor income] to the bishop's stead, but the out-goings did not lessen at all. Bishop Clong himself handed over the management of the stead, and gave it into the hands of bishop Thor-lac and the men whom he chose to help him therein. And the last season that bishop Clong was alive he well-nigh never rose out of his bed. Wherefore he made him ready against his death, as a wise man would especially choose to do after long sickness.

100

12. Clong was hallowed bishop in the days of pope Eugenius by archbishop Ans-kell, and in the days of Ey-stan and Sigurd, kings of Norway. He was then seven winters of the fifth ten [47], and he was bishop four-and-twenty winters. He died three nights after Matthias-mass [Feb. 28], and so his anniversary goes — but four if it be a leap-year; it was then Washing-day [Saturday] in Ember-days after Good Friday. There were then passed from the birth of Christ according to the general count of years, eleven hundred and sixty-nine years [1176]. And he was buried beside the other bishops. But abbot Thor-lac stood over him both at his burial and his death, and it was in every way lucky for him that such a man should stand by him both in his life and death as the blessed bishop Thor-lac is now proved before God to be.

101

13. Many great tidings befell while Clong was bishop, though here not many are set down. There was the fall of the brethren, the sons of Gelle, the kings of Norway, Sigurd first and then Ey-stan, and last Inge,

and the death of archbishop John, and the fall of Hacon Broad-shoulders, and the death of Beorn bishop of Holar. In the days of bishop Glong was the martyrdom of Saint Thomas, archbishop in England. And in his days there came fire up in Hecla-fell for the second time. There was also an earthquake whereby there was loss of life. These men (Icelanders) died while Clong was bishop: John Sigmund's son, and Hren the abbot, Paul Thord's son, and God-mund Cetil's son, priest Beorn-hedin the son of Sigurd, and Beine his brother. The slaughter of Helge Shafto's son, and Nicholas Sigurd's son was cut down at that time in Thrand-ham.

102

14. Now it must be manifest to us that there hath never been a man of such magnificence in many ways in Iceland as bishop Glong was, and we may also believe that his munificence will be remembered as long as Iceland is inhabited.

103

[Epilogue and Prologue.]

104

Now we have come to the history that is to be told of the blessed bishop Thor-lac, and this history [of him] is here composed for the entertainment of good men [and for their good], as the others were which have been written down here before. And well as the history of each one goes, yet is there no fairer example in every way than that which shall be told of that precious friend of God, bishop Thor-lac, who by right may be called Beam and Gem of Saints, both in this land and other places throughout the world. He may of a truth be called the Apostle of Iceland, just as the holy Patrec is called the Apostle of Ireland, for both these performed the mighty works of the very apostles in their preaching and long-suffering towards disobedient and wicked men.